

Confessions of a *Cheating Girlfriend III*

Lies, lust, and
sneaking upstairs
Part 3



JJ Vale

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PMI

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Saturday morning I told Silas I was going for a run. Sunday I said I needed to pick up groceries. Each time I ended up in Myles's apartment, in his bed, learning new ways our bodies fit together.

Sunday afternoon he had me on my hands and knees on the bed. He knelt behind me, one hand gripping my hip, the other pressing between my shoulder blades, pushing my chest down to the mattress. The position left me completely exposed to him.

He pushed inside slowly, letting me feel every inch. From this angle everything felt tighter, more intense. He withdrew almost completely, then slid back in with agonizing slowness.

"Faster," I said.

"No."

He maintained that slow rhythm, each thrust deliberate and controlled. His hand slid around my hip and between my legs, finding my clit. He circled it with his thumb while continuing those slow, deep strokes.

The combination was maddening. I tried to push back against him, to take him deeper, to speed things up. But his hand on my back held me in place.

"Please," I said.

"Not yet."

He kept me there on the edge for what felt like hours. Every time I got close he would change the pressure of his thumb or slow down even more. My arms were shaking. My thighs trembled.

"Myles, please."

"Tell me what you need."

"You know what I need."

"Say it."

"I need to come. Please let me come."

He increased the pressure of his thumb and thrust harder. Three strokes and I was falling apart, my face pressed into his pillow, my whole body shaking. He followed moments later, both hands gripping my hips so hard I knew there would be marks.

I collapsed forward onto the bed. He lay beside me, his hand on my lower back.

"I have to go," I said when I could breathe again. "I've been gone too long."

"Five more minutes."

"I don't have five minutes."

But I stayed anyway, lying there while he traced patterns on my skin. When I finally got up and dressed, my legs were unsteady.

Downstairs, Silas was making dinner. He looked up when I came in with my empty grocery bags.

"Forget something?" he asked.

"What?"

"The groceries."

My mind went blank. "Oh. They didn't have what I needed. I'll go to the other store tomorrow."

He nodded and went back to chopping vegetables. I went to the bathroom and looked at myself in the mirror. My lips were swollen. My neck had a faint red mark where Myles had sucked too hard. I pulled my collar higher and went back out.

We ate dinner in front of the television. Silas's leg pressed against mine and I felt nothing but the urge to move away. When he went to bed I stayed up, listening to the footsteps overhead, knowing Myles was awake too.

My phone buzzed. A text from him.

I can still feel you.

I stared at the words. I should delete them. Should tell him to stop texting me. Instead I wrote back.

Me too.

Tomorrow?

I work until 6.

Come after.

Okay.

I deleted the conversation and went to bed. Silas was already asleep. I lay in the dark and thought about the way Myles's hands felt on my skin, the sounds he made, the look in his eyes when he was inside me.

Monday I went straight from work to his apartment. He had me pressed against the wall before I even got my shoes off. His mouth was on my neck, my collarbone. His hands pulled up my shirt and he took my breast in his mouth through my bra.

"I thought about you all day," he said against my skin.

I didn't respond. Couldn't respond. His hand was already sliding into my jeans, his fingers finding me wet and ready.

"Bedroom," I managed.

We made it to the hallway. He pushed me against the wall there and pulled down my jeans. I stepped out of them and he lifted me, my back against the wall, my legs around his waist. He was still wearing his jeans but he unzipped them just enough and then he was pushing inside me.

The position was awkward, the angle strange. But I didn't care. I gripped his shoulders and let him take me there in the hallway, hard and fast, both of us too desperate to make it to the bed.

When we finished we slid down the wall and sat on the floor, breathing hard. He kissed me slow and deep, his hand cupping my face.

"Come on," he said finally, standing and offering his hand.

We went to the bedroom. This time was different. He laid me on the bed and just looked at me for a long moment. Then he kissed his way down my body, taking his time. His mouth found my breast and he worked it until I was arching into him. Then he moved to the other side, giving it the same attention.

He kissed down my ribs, my stomach. His hands slid up my inner thighs, spreading them wide. He settled between my legs and put his mouth on me.

His tongue moved in slow circles, then quick flicks. He slid two fingers inside me and curved them, finding that spot. I fisted my hands in his hair, torn between pulling him closer and pushing him away from the overwhelming sensation.

He brought me to the edge three times, then backed off. By the fourth time I was begging incoherently. When he finally let me finish I had to cover my mouth with my own hand to keep from screaming.

Before I recovered he flipped me onto my stomach and pulled my hips up. He pushed inside from behind and the angle made me gasp. He set a brutal pace, one hand fisted in my hair, the other gripping my hip.

"Is this what you need?" he asked, his voice rough.

I couldn't form words. Just nodded and gripped the sheets.

He released my hair and both hands went to my hips. The sound of skin against skin filled the room. I was so sensitive from the previous climax that everything felt like too much. But I didn't want him to stop.

When I came again it caught me by surprise, sudden and intense. I clenched around him and he cursed, his rhythm faltering. Three more thrusts and he finished too.

We collapsed on the bed. I rolled onto my back, staring at the ceiling, my whole body buzzing.

"What time do you have to be home?" he asked.

I looked at my phone. Seven-thirty. "Now, probably."

"Stay for dinner."

"I can't."

"Why not? Tell him you're eating with a coworker."

"He'll think that's weird. I don't do that."

"Then start doing it."

I sat up and started getting dressed. He watched from the bed, still naked.

"You're going to have to choose eventually," he said.

"I know."

"When?"

"I don't know."

I left before he could push further.

Tuesday Silas had a late class. I told him I was doing laundry. Instead I went to Myles's apartment and we didn't even make it past the living room. He bent me over the back of the couch and took me there, my hands gripping the cushions, his hand over my mouth to keep me quiet.

Wednesday he came to the laundry room. We heard footsteps on the stairs and froze, pressed against the washing machine, my jeans around my ankles. The footsteps passed and continued up to the second floor. We finished in silence, the risk of being caught making everything sharper.

Thursday I called in sick to work and spent four hours in his bed. He tried every position we hadn't done yet. Me on top facing away from him so he could watch himself disappear inside me. Both of us on our sides, him behind me, one of my legs hooked over his hip. Me sitting on the edge of the bed with him standing, my legs wrapped around his waist.

Each position felt different, hit different spots. By the time I left I could barely walk straight. Silas noticed when I came home.

"You okay? You're walking funny."

"I think I pulled something at the gym."

"You went to the gym?"

"Yeah. Thought I'd try something new."

Another lie. They came so easily now.

Friday evening Myles texted me while I was at work.

Tonight. Tell him you're going out with coworkers.

I stared at my phone. Going out meant hours, not the quick stolen moments I'd been managing. It meant bigger lies, more elaborate deception.

I don't know.

Please. I need more than twenty minutes with you.

I thought about it through my whole shift. When I got off work I sat in my car and pulled out my phone.

"Hey," I said when Silas answered. "Some people from work are going out for drinks. Is it okay if I go?"

"Yeah, sure. Have fun."

That was it. No questions about where or with who or what time I'd be home. Just casual acceptance.

I drove to the house and parked around the corner instead of in the driveway. Then I climbed the stairs to 12.

Myles had cooked. There was pasta and salad on the table, candles lit. The domesticity of it made my chest tight.

"What's this?" I asked.

"Dinner. We've never had dinner."

We sat and ate. The conversation was easy, natural. He told me about a difficult client. I told him about the regular customer who always ordered the most complicated drink on the menu. It felt normal in a way nothing with Silas felt anymore.

After dinner we moved to the couch. He pulled me against him and we just sat there for a while, his hand in my hair. No urgency, no rush. Just being together.

"This is nice," he said.

"Yeah."

"We could have this all the time."

I didn't respond. The suggestion hung in the air between us.

Eventually his hand slid under my shirt. The touching started slow but built quickly. We undressed each other on the couch, taking our time. He laid me down and settled between my legs, pushing inside slowly.

This time felt different. Less frantic, more deliberate. He moved with steady strokes, his eyes on mine. One hand laced with mine, pinning it beside my head. The intimacy of it made my throat tight.

He brought me to the edge slowly, building the pressure with each movement. When I finally came it was gentle, rolling through me in long waves. He followed moments later, his face buried in my neck.

We lay tangled on the couch afterward. His hand traced patterns on my back. Neither of us spoke. Words would make this real in a way the physical didn't.

At eleven I finally got up and dressed. He walked me to the door.

"When can I see you again?" he asked.

"Tomorrow. I'll figure something out."

He kissed me slow and deep. I felt it in my chest, in my stomach, everywhere.

Downstairs, the apartment was dark. Silas was already in bed. I slipped in beside him and he didn't stir. I lay there smelling like sex and another man and he had no idea.

The guilt should have destroyed me. Instead I fell asleep thinking about tomorrow, about the next time, about how I could stretch the lies to get more hours with Myles.

Saturday I told Silas I was meeting an old friend who was in town. He barely looked up from his laptop.

"Have fun," he said.

I spent six hours with Myles. We had sex three times, slept between rounds, ordered takeout and ate it in bed. It felt like playing house, like pretending we were a real couple instead of whatever we actually were.

Sunday I said I was going for a long run. I was gone for four hours. Silas didn't question it.

The lies were getting bigger, easier. I was constructing an entire alternate life and he noticed nothing. Part of me wanted him to notice, to catch me, to force the decision I couldn't make myself. But he was too absorbed in his thesis, too comfortable in his assumptions about me.

Monday morning I woke before dawn. Silas was still asleep. I pulled on my running clothes and went upstairs.

Myles answered the door sleepy-eyed. I pushed him back into the apartment and kissed him. We stumbled to the bedroom and I climbed on top of him, still wearing my running clothes. I pulled them off piece by piece while he watched, his hands on my hips.

When I sank down onto him we both groaned. I rode him slowly, my hands on his chest. The morning light through the window made everything

soft, dreamlike.

"You're so beautiful like this," he said, his hands sliding up to cup my breasts.

I increased my pace. He sat up and wrapped his arms around me, changing the angle. Now we were face to face, chest to chest, as close as two people could be.

He thrust up into me and I matched his rhythm. Our foreheads pressed together, our breathing mingling. The intimacy of it was almost unbearable. I closed my eyes but he caught my chin.

"Look at me," he said.

I opened my eyes and met his gaze. The connection was too much, too raw. I tried to look away but he held my face steady.

"Don't hide from me."

I couldn't hide. Not like this, joined and moving together, his eyes seeing everything I tried to keep locked away. The pressure built and I felt myself climbing toward release, my movements becoming erratic.

"That's it," he said. "Let me see you."

I came apart while looking into his eyes, unable to hide anything. He followed moments later, his arms tightening around me.

We stayed like that, wrapped around each other, until our breathing slowed. Finally I pulled away and started dressing. He watched from the bed.

"Same time tomorrow?" he asked.

"Maybe earlier. Before he even wakes up."

"I'll be ready."

I went downstairs and slipped back into bed beside Silas just as his alarm went off. He rolled over and kissed my shoulder.

"Morning run?" he asked groggily.

"Yeah. Just got back."

He got up and shuffled to the bathroom. I lay there still feeling Myles inside me, still seeing his eyes on mine, and wondered how much longer I could maintain this double life.

That night Silas reached for me in bed. His hand slid under my shirt and I froze. I hadn't let him touch me in over a week. If I kept refusing he would notice, would start asking questions.

"Okay," I said quietly.

He kissed my neck while his hand moved to my breast. His touch felt foreign after so much time with Myles. Too gentle, too tentative. He moved over me and I spread my legs, letting him settle between them.

He pushed inside and I felt nothing. No heat, no desire, just the mechanical sensation of it. He moved with his usual rhythm, steady and predictable. I made the sounds I thought I should make, moved my hips the way he expected.

It was over in minutes. He kissed my forehead and rolled off, asleep within moments.

I lay there feeling hollowed out and wrong. Letting Silas touch me felt like a different kind of betrayal than what I was doing with Myles. At least with Myles I wanted it. This felt like using Silas to maintain a lie.

I went to the bathroom and showered, scrubbing everywhere he had touched me.

Tuesday afternoon Silas told me he had to meet his advisor at two. I was working the early shift, off at noon.

"I'll be home around six," he said. "Want me to pick up dinner?"

"Sure. Whatever you want."

The moment his car left I texted Myles.

Come down.

Three minutes later there was a knock on our apartment door. I opened it and he walked in, his eyes scanning the space. He'd never been inside before, not properly. Just that one time when Silas caught him at the door.

"We have four hours," I said.

He looked at me, then at the bedroom door. Something dark flickered across his face.

"Here?" he asked.

"Here."

He crossed to me and kissed me hard. His hands were already pulling at my clothes. We stumbled toward the bedroom and I pushed the door open. Silas's clothes were scattered on the floor. His books stacked on the nightstand. The bed we shared every night.

Myles pushed me onto it.

The wrongness of it should have stopped me. Should have made me pull back, say no, maintain some kind of boundary. Instead it made everything more intense. He pulled off my jeans and spread my legs wide, settling between them.

"This is where you sleep with him," he said, his hand sliding between my legs.

"Don't."

"Don't what? Don't acknowledge it?" He pushed two fingers inside me. "You're wet."

I was. The forbidden nature of it, the complete destruction of boundaries, made my body respond in ways my mind couldn't justify.

He pulled his fingers out and brought them to my mouth. "Taste."

I opened my mouth and he slid them inside. I sucked them clean while maintaining eye contact. His jaw clenched.

"Where do you want me?" he asked.

"Everywhere."

He stripped off his clothes and mine. Then he took me on Silas's side of the bed, hard and rough, my hands gripping the headboard that Silas and I had picked out together. The sheets smelled like our laundry detergent. The pillows still had the indents from where we slept.

When Myles flipped me over and took me from behind, I looked at Silas's nightstand. His thesis notes. His glasses. The picture of us from two years ago, both of us smiling, back when things were still good.

I came looking at that picture, the guilt and arousal so tangled I couldn't separate them.

After, we lay in the bed. Myles pulled me against his chest and I let him, my head on the pillow where Silas slept every night.

"We still have three hours," he said.

We used them. We had sex twice more in that bed, in positions Silas and I had never tried. Myles bent me over the dresser where Silas kept his clothes. He took me against the wall that had our photos hanging on it. He fucked me in every corner of the room, claiming the space in ways that felt permanent.

At five-thirty I made him leave. I stripped the bed completely and washed everything. I opened the windows to air out the room. I cleaned the dresser, the nightstand, erasing any evidence.

When Silas came home at six the apartment smelled like cleaning products. He found me folding the fresh laundry.

"Spring cleaning?" he asked.

"Just felt like it."

We ate the Thai food he brought home. I pushed the food around my plate, unable to eat. My body still ached from the afternoon. I could still feel Myles everywhere.

That night when Silas climbed into the clean sheets, he noticed nothing. I lay beside him thinking about how Myles had been in this exact spot just hours ago. How I had let him take me in the bed I shared with my boyfriend. How far I had fallen and how little I cared.

After that, the floodgates opened. Wednesday morning Myles texted me. *Laundry room. Now.*

Silas was in the shower. I went upstairs and Myles was waiting. He pushed me against the washing machine and took me there, standing up, my legs wrapped around him. We finished just as we heard footsteps on the stairs. I barely got my clothes adjusted before someone from the second floor walked in.

Thursday he came to the apartment again while Silas was at class. This time we didn't make it to the bedroom. He bent me over the kitchen table and took me there. After, while I was still bent over the table catching my breath, he ran his hand down my back.

"I want you to think about this every time you eat dinner here," he said.

Friday evening Silas went to a faculty mixer. I told him I had a headache and stayed home. The moment his car left I texted Myles to come down.

He arrived with a bottle of wine. We drank it on the couch where Silas and I watched television every night. Myles's hand slid up my thigh and I spread my legs for him, let him touch me on the same cushions where Silas sat oblivious night after night.

"Bedroom," I said when I couldn't take anymore.

We went to the bedroom and this time was different. Slower, more deliberate. He took his time undressing me, kissing each piece of exposed skin. When he finally pushed inside me it felt different than the frantic sessions we'd been having.

He moved with long, slow strokes. His hand found mine and our fingers laced together. He kissed me deep and thorough while maintaining that steady rhythm.

"Stay with me tonight," he said against my mouth. "Come upstairs and stay."

"I can't. He'll be home by eleven."

"Then come after. Tell him you can't sleep and you're going for a walk. Come to me."

"That's insane."

"I don't care. I need more than stolen hours."

He thrust deeper and I gasped. He knew exactly how to move to make me lose my train of thought.

"Please," he said. "Just once. Stay the whole night with me."

"I'll think about it."

"That's not a yes."

"It's not a no either."

He increased his pace, his rhythm becoming less controlled. I wrapped my legs around him and matched his movements. When I came it was intense, rolling through me in waves that seemed endless. He followed moments later, his face buried in my neck.

After, we lay tangled in the sheets. His hand traced idle patterns on my back.

"I'm serious," he said. "About tonight. About you staying."

"Let me see how late he stays out."

At ten-thirty I made Myles leave. I cleaned up again, erasing evidence. Silas came home at eleven-fifteen, slightly drunk from the wine at the mixer.

"How's your headache?" he asked.

"Better."

He kissed me and went to brush his teeth. I sat on the bed and looked at my phone. A text from Myles.

Come up. He's drunk. He won't notice.

I stared at the message. It was true. Silas was drunk and tired. He would fall asleep immediately. I could slip out and he would never know.

I waited until his breathing evened out, until I was sure he was asleep. Then I got up carefully and pulled on clothes. I walked to the door, my heart pounding.

My hand was on the doorknob when I stopped. This was different from the daytime meetings, different from the laundry room encounters. This was me choosing to leave him while he slept to go to another man's bed.

I opened the door.

I climbed the stairs as quietly as I could and knocked softly on 12. Myles opened it immediately, like he'd been waiting by the door.

"You came," he said.

"I'm here."

He pulled me inside and kissed me hard. We went to his bedroom and he undressed me slowly, reverently. This time there was no rush, no ticking clock. We had hours.

He laid me on the bed and took his time exploring my body. His mouth moved everywhere, learning what made me gasp, what made me arch into him. When he finally settled between my legs and pushed inside, it felt different than it ever had before.

We moved together slowly, building something that felt less like sex and more like something I couldn't name. His eyes stayed on mine. His hand cupped my face. When I came it was gentle, rolling through me in long waves.

He followed moments later and then pulled me against his chest. We lay there in the dark, his hand in my hair, and I felt something crack open inside me.

"Don't go back," he said quietly. "Stay here. Just stay."

I should have said no. Should have pulled away and run back downstairs before Silas woke up and found me gone. Instead I closed my eyes and let myself stay.

I fell asleep in Myles's arms while my boyfriend slept alone one floor below.

I woke at five in a panic. The sky was just starting to lighten. Myles was still asleep beside me.

I dressed quickly and slipped out of his apartment. Downstairs, I opened our door as quietly as possible and crept into the bedroom. Silas was still asleep, in the exact same position I'd left him.

I slipped back into bed and lay there with my heart racing. I had done it. I had slept the whole night with Myles while Silas slept alone.

When Silas's alarm went off at six-thirty, he rolled over and kissed my shoulder.

"Morning," he mumbled.

"Morning."

He got up and went to the shower. I lay there feeling like I was made of lies, constructed entirely from deception. But I couldn't make myself feel bad enough to stop.

That afternoon Myles texted me.

Tonight. Do it again.

I can't do it every night.

Why not?

Because eventually he'll wake up and I won't be there.

Then leave him. Come stay with me for real.

I stared at the message for a long time. My thumb hovered over the keyboard. It would be so easy to say yes. To pack my things and go upstairs and stop living this double life.

But I couldn't make myself type the words.

I need more time.

How much more time?

I don't know.

He didn't respond.

Thursday night Silas came home exhausted from back-to-back meetings with his advisor. He fell asleep before ten, his arm draped across my waist. I lay there staring at the ceiling, feeling the weight of his arm like a chain.

At eleven I carefully lifted his arm and slid out from under it. He stirred but didn't wake, just rolled onto his back. I stood beside the bed watching him sleep, his face relaxed and untroubled. The guilt twisted in my stomach but it wasn't enough to stop me.

I pulled on clothes in the dark and slipped out of the apartment. The stairs to 12 felt like they were getting shorter each time I climbed them, the path too familiar.

Myles opened the door before I could knock. He pulled me inside and we went straight to the bedroom. We undressed each other without speaking, the routine established. When we were both naked he laid me on the bed and settled between my legs.

He pushed inside and we both exhaled. The familiarity of it should have made it feel less intense, but it didn't. Every time felt like the first time, overwhelming and necessary.

We moved together in the dark. His mouth found mine and we kissed while our bodies found their rhythm. When I came it was silent, my face pressed against his shoulder. He followed moments later, his hands gripping my hips.

After, I lay against his chest listening to his heartbeat slow. His hand moved through my hair in steady strokes.

"How long can you stay?" he asked.

"A few hours."

"Stay until morning."

"I can't. What if he wakes up?"

"He never wakes up."

It was true. Silas slept like the dead once he was out. Still, the risk felt too great.

"Just a few hours," I said.

But his hand in my hair was soothing and his heartbeat was steady under my ear and I was so tired from the constant vigilance, the endless sneaking. My eyes grew heavy.

"Don't fall asleep," he murmured.

"I won't."

But I did.

I woke to dim early light. The room was gray with pre-dawn. I grabbed my phone from the nightstand.

Five-forty-five.

Relief flooded through me. Silas's alarm didn't go off until six-thirty. I had time.

I started to get up but Myles's arm tightened around me.

"Stay," he said, his voice rough with sleep.

"I can't. I need to get back before he wakes up."

"Five more minutes."

"I don't have five minutes."

But his hand slid down my side, over my hip. His mouth found my neck. I felt him hardening against me.

"Myles, I really need to, "

He rolled me onto my back and settled between my legs. He pushed inside me before I could finish the sentence and I gasped. This position was different in the morning light, less hidden by darkness. I could see his face clearly, the intensity in his eyes.

He moved slowly, deliberately. Each stroke deep and measured. His hand cupped my face and his thumb brushed across my lips.

"Look at me," he said.

I met his eyes and couldn't look away. The intimacy of it made my chest tight. He increased his pace slightly and I wrapped my legs around him, pulling him deeper.

"I need you to come for me," he said. "Before you go."

His hand slid between us and found my clit. The dual sensation made my breathing change. He maintained that rhythm, his eyes still on mine, until I felt everything tighten. When I came it was while looking directly at him, unable to hide anything.

He thrust twice more and followed, his forehead pressed against mine.

I lay there catching my breath, aware of time slipping away. I grabbed my phone.

Six-fifteen.

"Fuck, I really need to go."

I dressed quickly while Myles watched from the bed. At the door he pulled me into one more kiss.

"Tonight?" he asked.

"Maybe."

But we both knew it was yes.

I went downstairs and slipped back into the apartment. The bedroom was still dark. I could hear Silas's steady breathing. I undressed and climbed back into bed, my heart racing.

Fifteen minutes later his alarm went off. He rolled over and kissed my shoulder.

"Morning," he mumbled.

"Morning."

He got up and went to the shower. I lay there with my pulse still elevated, replaying how close I had cut it.

Friday night I told myself I wouldn't go. I lay beside Silas after he fell asleep, counting the reasons I should stay. But at midnight I was sliding out from under his arm and climbing the stairs.

Saturday he fell asleep early after a long day at the library. I waited thirty minutes to be sure, then slipped out.

Sunday night I made it until one in the morning before I gave in.

Each time I told myself I would just go for an hour, maybe two. Each time I ended up falling asleep in Myles's arms, waking in a panic at dawn, rushing back downstairs before Silas's alarm.

Monday night I slipped out at eleven-thirty. Tuesday at midnight. Wednesday I waited until one.

Thursday night Silas had been up late working. He didn't fall asleep until after eleven. I lay beside him, waiting for his breathing to deepen. At twelve-thirty I carefully lifted his arm from around my waist.

He stirred. I froze.

"Bathroom," I whispered.

He made a sleepy sound and rolled over. I waited until his breathing evened out again, then slipped out of bed. I pulled on clothes and left the apartment.

Upstairs, Myles was waiting. We went to his bedroom and this time was urgent, both of us too desperate to go slow. He pushed me against the wall and took me there, my legs wrapped around him, my hands gripping his shoulders.

We barely made it to the bed afterward. We collapsed onto it and he pulled me against his chest. His hand moved through my hair in those familiar strokes.

"I hate watching you leave," he said quietly.

"I know."

"Stay until morning. Please."

"What if he wakes up?"

"He won't."

"But what if he does?"

"Then maybe it's time for him to know."

I didn't respond. The thought of Silas knowing terrified me. Not because I would lose him, I had already lost him, or maybe he had never really been mine to lose. But because it would force me to make a choice, to face consequences, to become something real instead of just existing in this suspended state.

"Just until six," Myles said. "You always wake up in time."

"I don't know."

But I was already feeling my eyes grow heavy. His heartbeat was steady under my ear. The bed was comfortable. I was so tired of the constant vigilance.

"Just rest a little," he said. "I'll make sure you wake up."

I meant to stay awake. Meant to keep checking my phone, watching the time. But the exhaustion of the week caught up with me. The last thing I remember was his hand in my hair and thinking I would just close my eyes for a few minutes.

I woke to bright sunlight streaming through the window. My phone was buzzing on the nightstand. I grabbed it and my entire body went cold.

Nine-thirty-seven.

Six missed calls from Silas. Four text messages.

Where are you?

Briana are you okay?

This isn't funny. Where did you go?

I'm really worried. Call me right now.

"No no no no." I sat up fast, my hands shaking so badly I almost dropped the phone.

Myles woke beside me. "What's wrong?"

"It's almost ten. He's been calling."

I scrambled out of bed and pulled on my clothes. My mind was racing but no excuses made sense. I couldn't say I went for a run, not at this hour. Couldn't say I went to the store. Nothing explained being gone from five in the morning until now.

"Just tell him," Myles said, sitting up.

"Tell him what? That I've been sneaking up here every night?"

"Tell him the truth. That you're not happy. That this isn't working."

"I can't just, I need to think."

I ran out of his apartment and down the stairs. At our door I stopped with my hand on the knob. My whole body was shaking. I had no excuse prepared, no story that made sense.

I opened the door.

Silas was standing in the living room, fully dressed, his phone in his hand. When he saw me his expression shifted from worry to confusion to something harder.

"Where the hell were you?" he asked.

"I'm so sorry. I went for a walk and I ran into Myles and we got talking and I completely lost track of time."

"You've been with Myles? For four hours?"

"We went to that diner on Foster. The one that's open all night. I know I should have texted but my phone died and I just, I wasn't thinking."

He stared at me. "You went to a diner with the guy from upstairs at five in the morning?"

"I couldn't sleep. I went out for air and I ran into him outside. He was coming back from the gym and we just started talking and, " I let my voice break slightly. "I'm sorry. I know you were worried. My phone died and I didn't realize how late it was getting."

"You've been at a diner. Talking."

"Yes."

"About what?"

"Just, everything. Life. His job. My job. He's been going through some stuff with his mom and I was telling him about my parents' divorce." The lies came so easily now, each one building on the last. "We're friends, Silas. That's all. We're just friends."

He looked at me for a long moment. I could see him trying to decide whether to believe me.

"Your phone's dead?" he asked.

I pulled it from my pocket and pressed the power button. The screen stayed black. I had let it die on purpose weeks ago, keeping it off when I was with Myles. "See?"

He exhaled slowly. "You could have used his phone to text me."

"You're right. I should have. I wasn't thinking. I'm really sorry."

"This is the second time you've disappeared for hours. First that walk to the park, now this."

"I know. I've just been, I don't know. Restless lately. Feeling cooped up." I moved closer to him. "But it's nothing bad. I promise. Myles is just a friend. We talk sometimes. That's all."

"You talk sometimes."

"Yes. Is that okay?"

He studied my face. I kept my expression open, apologetic. Finally his shoulders dropped.

"Yeah. It's fine. I just, when I woke up and you were gone, I thought something happened to you."

"I'm sorry. I'll be more careful about telling you when I leave. And I'll make sure my phone is charged."

He nodded. "Okay."

"Are we good?"

"Yeah. We're good." He pulled me into a hug. I wrapped my arms around him and felt nothing but relief that he had believed me. "I'm going to make coffee. You want some?"

"Yes. Let me charge my phone first."

I went to the bedroom and plugged in my phone, my hands still shaking. That was too close. Way too close. I needed to be more careful about the time, about falling asleep.

My phone powered on and immediately buzzed with texts from Myles.

Are you okay?

What happened?

Did he believe you?

I typed back quickly.

Yes. He believed me. But we need to be more careful.

I told you to just tell him the truth.

I can't. Not yet.

When?

I don't know.

I deleted the conversation and went back out to the living room. Silas handed me coffee and we sat on the couch together. His arm went around me and I leaned into him, playing the part.

"So you and Myles are friends now?" he asked.

"Yeah. He's nice. Easy to talk to."

"That's good. You should have friends."

The irony of it made my stomach turn. "Yeah."

"Maybe we should have him over for dinner sometime. The three of us."

My heart stopped. "What?"

"If you're friends with him, we should get to know him. Be neighborly."

"I don't know if that's necessary."

"Why not? It might be nice."

I couldn't think of anything worse than sitting at a table with both of them, pretending everything was normal.

"Maybe," I said. "Let me ask him."

"Okay."

He kissed the top of my head and went back to his coffee. I sat there feeling sick, thinking about how easily the lies had come, how quickly he had accepted them.

We're just friends.

The words echoed in my head. Four words that let me keep both of them, that let me continue the double life. Four words that made me hate myself even as I knew I would keep using them.

That night I waited until Silas was asleep, then I slipped out again. I couldn't help myself. The close call that morning should have scared me straight, should have made me stop. Instead it just made everything more intense.

Myles opened the door and pulled me inside.

"That was stupid this morning," he said.

"I know."

"You need to tell him."

"He thinks we're just friends now. It's fine."

"It's not fine. You're living a lie."

"I know that." I pulled him toward the bedroom. "Can we not talk about this right now?"

We went to bed and this time I set an alarm on my phone. Five-thirty. That would give me time to get back before Silas woke up.

When it went off in the pre-dawn darkness, I silenced it and got dressed. Myles watched me from the bed.

"Same time tomorrow?" he asked.

"Probably."

"We're just friends though, right?"

The sarcasm in his voice made me flinch. "Don't."

"Don't what? Don't point out that you're lying to him? Don't acknowledge what we're actually doing?"

"I need more time."

"You keep saying that."

I left without kissing him goodbye. Downstairs, I slipped back into bed beside Silas. When his alarm went off thirty minutes later, he rolled over and smiled at me sleepily.

"Morning," he said.

"Morning."

"Sleep okay?"

"Yeah. You?"

"Great."

He got up and went to the shower. I lay there thinking about Myles's words. About how long I could keep this up. About what I was becoming.

But I already knew the answer. I could keep it up as long as they both let me. As long as Silas kept believing my lies and Myles kept opening his door.

I was weak and selfish and I couldn't stop.

And I didn't even want to try.

The next two weeks continued the same pattern. I would slip out of bed while Silas slept and go upstairs to Myles. We would have sex, I would fall asleep in his arms, my alarm would wake me before dawn, and I would

sneak back downstairs. During the day I played the role of girlfriend, making dinner, asking about his thesis, maintaining the illusion.

Silas never questioned me again. He had accepted the explanation that Myles and I were just friends. Sometimes he would ask if I had seen him lately and I would say yes, we ran into each other doing laundry or in the driveway. Just casual, neighborly interactions. Nothing to worry about.

But the double life was wearing on me. The constant lies, the vigilance, the guilt that never fully went away. I felt split in two, neither version of myself fully real.

One evening Silas mentioned having Myles over for dinner again.

"You keep saying you'll ask him," he said. "Why don't we just do it? This Friday?"

I looked at him across the table. An idea formed in my mind, terrible and reckless. If I couldn't tell him the truth with words, maybe I could show him. Maybe I could force the decision I was too weak to make myself.

"Okay," I said. "I'll ask him."

Friday evening arrived. I had texted Myles earlier.

Come down at 7. Silas wants to have dinner with us.

Are you serious?

Yes.

Why would you do this?

Just come. Please.

This is a bad idea.

I know.

At seven there was a knock on the door. Silas answered it while I stood in the kitchen, my heart pounding.

"Myles, hey," Silas said. "Come in."

Myles stepped inside. His eyes found mine across the room and I saw the question there, the confusion. I looked away.

"Thanks for having me," Myles said.

"Of course. Briana says you two have become friends. Figured it was time we all hung out properly."

We sat at the kitchen table. I had made pasta, simple and safe. The conversation started awkward, stilted. Silas asked about Myles's training work. Myles asked about the thesis. I said almost nothing, just pushed food around my plate.

The tension was unbearable. Myles kept looking at me, trying to understand what I was doing. Silas was oblivious, playing the friendly host.

After dinner we moved to the living room. Silas poured wine. We sat on the couch, me in the middle, Silas on one side, Myles on the other. The wrongness of it made my skin crawl.

Silas excused himself to use the bathroom. The moment he left, Myles leaned close.

"What are you doing?" he whispered.

"I don't know."

"This is insane."

"I know."

His hand found my thigh under the blanket that was draped across the couch. The touch sent electricity through me. I should have pushed his hand away. Should have maintained the pretense.

Instead I let it stay there.

Silas came back and sat down. He picked up his wine glass and took a sip. We sat there in silence, some show playing on the television that none of us were watching.

Myles's hand moved higher on my thigh. My breathing changed. I felt myself getting wet just from that simple touch, from the danger of it happening right here with Silas less than two feet away.

I turned my head to look at Myles. He was looking back at me with dark eyes. Something passed between us, an understanding, a challenge.

I leaned toward him and kissed him.

For a second everything stopped. Then Myles's hand went to the back of my neck and he kissed me back, deep and thorough, the way he kissed me upstairs in his bed.

"What the fuck?" Silas's voice cut through the haze.

I pulled back from Myles but his hand stayed on my neck. I turned to look at Silas. His face was pale, his wine glass frozen halfway to his mouth.

"Briana, what the fuck are you doing?"

I didn't answer. Couldn't answer. Myles's hand slid from my neck down to my breast and I gasped.

"Are you, " Silas stood up. "Are you fucking kidding me right now?"

Myles pulled me closer, his mouth on my neck. His hand slid under my shirt. I should have stopped him. Should have at least tried to explain.

Instead I let him touch me, let him pull my shirt over my head right there on the couch.

"Briana!" Silas's voice was sharp with shock. "What the hell is happening?"

I looked at him while Myles unhooked my bra and tossed it aside. "I'm sorry."

"You're sorry? You're, " He stared at us. Myles's mouth found my breast and I arched into him. "How long? How long has this been going on?"

"Weeks," I said.

"Weeks." He laughed, but it sounded broken. "The friend from upstairs. The one you're just friends with."

Myles pulled me onto his lap so I was straddling him. His hands worked at the button of my jeans. I lifted up so he could pull them down. Silas was right there, standing five feet away, watching everything.

"You should leave," I said to Silas, my voice breathless as Myles's hand slid into my underwear.

"Leave? This is my apartment."

"Then stay. I don't care."

Myles pulled my underwear aside and I felt him freeing himself from his jeans. Then he was positioning himself and pushing inside me in one smooth movement. I gasped and gripped his shoulders.

"Jesus Christ," Silas said. But he didn't leave. He sat back down on the chair across from us, his face pale, his eyes wide.

I started to move on Myles's lap, rising and sinking, taking him deep. His hands gripped my hips, guiding my movements. The fact that Silas was right there watching made everything sharper, more intense.

"You're really doing this," Silas said. His voice was hollow. "You're really fucking him right in front of me."

I looked at him while I rode Myles. "Yes."

"How long?" he asked again. "How long have you been lying to me?"

"Since the first time I went to the laundry room alone."

Myles thrust up into me and I moaned. His mouth found my neck, my collarbone. His hands moved over my body with the familiarity of someone who knew every inch of it.

"All those morning runs," Silas said. "All those extra shifts at work."

"Yes."

"The night you were gone until ten in the morning. You were with him."

"Yes."

"In his bed."

"Yes."

Myles flipped us so I was on my back on the couch. He pulled my jeans and underwear completely off and spread my legs wide. Then he pushed back inside me, harder now, his rhythm building.

I gripped the couch cushions and looked up at him. His eyes were dark and focused entirely on me. He thrust deep and I cried out.

"This is sick," Silas said. But he still didn't leave. He sat there watching us, his hands gripping the arms of his chair.

Myles pulled out and flipped me onto my stomach. He pulled my hips up and entered me from behind. This angle was deeper, almost too much. I buried my face in the couch to muffle my sounds.

"Look at him," Myles said, his hand in my hair, pulling my head up. "Look at your boyfriend while I fuck you."

I looked at Silas. Our eyes met. I saw everything there, the hurt, the betrayal, the shock. But underneath it something else. He was watching us with an intensity that made my stomach drop.

Myles increased his pace, his hands gripping my hips. The sound of skin against skin filled the room. I felt myself climbing toward release, the pressure building.

"Come for me," Myles said. "Come while he watches."

The words pushed me over. I fell apart around him, my whole body shaking. Myles thrust three more times and followed, his fingers digging into my hips.

We stayed like that for a moment, both breathing hard. Then he pulled out and I collapsed onto the couch. Myles sat beside me and pulled me against his chest, possessive and sure.

I looked at Silas. He was still sitting in the chair, his face unreadable.

"Get out," he said quietly.

"What?"

"Get. Out." His voice was flat, emotionless. "Pack your things and get out of my apartment."

I sat up, pulling the blanket around myself. "Silas, "

"Now. I want you gone now."

I stood on shaking legs and went to the bedroom. Behind me I heard Silas say something to Myles but I couldn't make out the words. I pulled on

clothes and started throwing things into bags. My clothes, my toiletries, my books. Three years of life in this apartment reduced to a few duffel bags.

When I came back out, Myles was standing by the door. Silas was still in the chair, staring at nothing.

"I'm sorry," I said.

"No you're not." He finally looked at me. "You're not sorry. You're just sorry you got caught."

He wasn't wrong.

"Go," he said. "Just go."

I picked up my bags. Myles took two of them from me and opened the door. I looked back at Silas one more time but he had turned away.

We climbed the stairs to apartment 12. Myles opened the door and I walked inside with my bags. He set them down in the bedroom and turned to me.

"Are you okay?" he asked.

"I don't know."

"You can stay here. As long as you need."

I looked around his apartment. It was smaller than the one downstairs. Sparse. Unfamiliar. But it was also where I had felt more alive in the past few weeks than I had in years.

"Okay," I said.

We stood there in his bedroom surrounded by my hastily packed bags, and I realized I had done it. I had destroyed my relationship with Silas in the most brutal way possible. Had forced him to see exactly what I had been doing, who I had become.

I should have felt devastated. Should have been crying, grieving the loss of three years together.

Instead I just felt relieved.

Myles pulled me into his arms and I leaned into him. This was my life now. This apartment, this man, this thing we had built on lies and stolen hours and complete disregard for anyone else.

"Come to bed," he said.

I followed him to the bed we had shared in secret for weeks. But now there were no secrets. No more sneaking, no more lies, no more double life.

I had chosen. Or maybe I had let the choice be made for me. Either way, I was here now.

Myles pulled me down beside him and I closed my eyes, listening to the silence from the apartment below, wondering if Silas was still sitting in that chair or if he had moved yet.

Wondering what kind of person it made me that I didn't really care.

Epilogue

That was six months ago.

I still work at the coffee shop. I still see Silas occasionally when he's coming or going from the apartment. We don't speak. He moved on quickly, there's a new girlfriend now, someone from his program. I see her sometimes through the window, sitting at the table where I used to sit.

I live in 12 with Myles. We share a bed every night. No more sneaking, no more alarms set for five in the morning. Just the straightforward reality of being together.

Sometimes I think about how it happened. How I went from being someone who would never cheat to someone who destroyed a three-year relationship without hesitation. How easy each step was, how natural the progression felt. One conversation in a laundry room led to coffee, led to touching, led to sex, led to nightly visits, led to complete betrayal.

I don't make excuses for myself. I know what I did. I know who I became.

But I also know that I feel more myself now than I ever did with Silas. Whether that makes me terrible or just honest, I can't say.

Myles is in the shower. I'm lying in bed looking at the ceiling, the same ceiling I used to stare at from below, wondering what was happening up here.

Now I know. And I still don't know if that makes me free or just lost.

But I'm here. And for better or worse, this is who I am now.

The girl who cheated. The girl who couldn't stop. The girl who chose desire over decency and never looked back.

I hear the shower turn off. In a minute Myles will come back to bed and pull me against him and everything will feel right again, the way it only feels right with him.

I close my eyes and wait. This is my life now. This is who I became.